

CLIENT BRIEF

Weekly Competition #2: The Artifact Sprint

THE CLIENT

My name's Marcus. I run a small financial planning practice out of Denver. I've got 60 clients, all between 35 and 55, mostly dual-income families with kids. Been doing this for 12 years.

Every single one of my clients asks me the same question in our first meeting: "are we okay?" They want to know if they're on track for retirement, if they're saving enough, if they should be worried. It's the question underneath every other question they ask me.

THE PROBLEM

I spend the first 20 minutes of every intro call walking through the same math on a whiteboard. Income, expenses, savings rate, retirement target, gap. It's the same conversation 60 times a year. By the time we get to the actual planning, I've burned a third of the meeting on arithmetic.

I want to send people something before our first call. Something they can play with on their own. They put their numbers in, they see where they stand, they come to our meeting already knowing the basics. That way I can spend our hour on actual planning, not math.

WHAT I NEED

An interactive tool I can send to a prospect before our first meeting. They put in their age, income, current savings, monthly savings rate, and target retirement age. It tells them where they stand. Are they on track? Behind? Ahead? By how much?

It doesn't need to be perfect financial modeling. It needs to be honest, clear, and useful enough that someone walks away with a real answer to "are we okay?"

HOW I THINK ABOUT "ON TRACK"

I use the 25x rule. You need roughly 25 times your annual expenses saved by retirement to live off of. So if someone spends \$80K a year, they need around \$2M. From there I back into a savings rate based on their current age, current savings, and target retirement age, assuming a 7% average return.

That's the methodology I'd use. If you want to use a different one (4% rule, replacement ratio, 10x salary, whatever), that's fine. Just explain it in your writeup so I know what I'm looking at.

WHEN THE NEWS ISN'T GOOD

This is the part most calculators get wrong. They show someone they're \$400K behind and leave them there. People close the tab and don't come back.

When someone's behind, the tool should tell them they're behind, but it should also show them what closing the gap actually looks like. How much more per month would they need to save? What if they retired two years later? What if they kept their current savings rate but worked one extra year? Give them a path, not a verdict.

THE VIBE

It can't feel like a bank calculator. Those things are sterile. People don't trust them and they don't engage with them. They put numbers in, get a number out, close the tab.

I want it to feel like talking to me. Honest when the news is good. Direct when it isn't. A real human walking someone through their numbers. If a 42 year old with two kids and a mortgage opens this thing, they should feel like someone who actually understands their life is on the other side of it.

The way I'm talking to you in this brief is the way the tool should talk to my prospects. Use this brief as your voice reference.

OUTPUT FORMAT

How you deliver the answer is up to you. A number, a paragraph, a chart, a traffic light, a conversation. Whatever works. The only test it has to pass: would I actually send this to a prospect?

KEEP IT SIMPLE

Don't overbuild this. I said it already but I'll say it again. It doesn't need to be perfect financial modeling. A prospect should be able to fill it out in under three minutes and walk away with a real answer. If you find yourself adding a twelfth input field, you've gone too far.

YOUR DELIVERABLE

An interactive artifact built in Claude. Plus a 100 word writeup covering who it's for, what it does, and one design choice you made and why.

WHAT WE'RE LOOKING FOR

Three things, in this order:

1. Does it solve Marcus's actual problem? Can a prospect use it before a call and show up better prepared?
2. Does it sound like Marcus? Read the brief. Does the tool match that voice?

3. Is it simple enough that a real person would actually finish it?

What we're NOT judging: financial accuracy, modeling complexity, or feature count. This is a design and voice challenge, not a finance challenge. You don't need to be a CFP to win this.

Clief Notes Weekly Competition | Submit by Saturday, May 2nd at 12:00 PM EST